10

On May 20, 1948, I got to school for my own death watch. The obsequies were to take place in Room 206 of the Low Library, a building and room with which I was unacquainted, so that I would not have the benefit of familiarity.

It began at 2:00 p.m. and after a lunch I had difficulty eating, I was ready. Or at least I was there.

It was clear that I was going to react in the second fashion: not paralysis, but hysteria. I was laughing as I went in.

I got up and gave my speech with only an occasional giggle, and then the questioning began.

It is no use asking me for the procedures in detail. I wrote nothing of it in my diary and I remember very little.

One fellow asked me how I knew the potassium iodide I used was indeed potassium iodide. My impulse was to answer truthfully that I never questioned it. It said "Potassium Iodide" on the label and that was enough for me.

Some dim instinct warned me that that was the wrong answer. I thought desperately and quickly and said, "Well sir, it dissolves as potassium iodide does, and yields iodine as potassium iodide does, and it gives me my end point as potassium iodide would, so it doesn't matter what it really is, does it?"

That was a good answer.

One fellow asked me how I knew that the enzyme I used was indeed derived from the mushroom species I said it was. I said that it came from mushrooms bought at the grocery store.

"So what?" said he.

"So Agaricus campestris is the only species sold in the grocery store."

"How can you be sure of that?"

Again I had to think rapidly. "If I had had any doubts, sir, I would have referred to a text on mushrooms."